quantity, priority given to players being fresh, both mentally and physically, rather than over-prepared.

There is no sleeping in the dressing room any more when we bat. Our batters are going at everything and, unbelievably, to begin with it pays off. Jonny Bairstow scores 136 in 92 balls, hunting down a total of 299 against New Zealand that many England teams would have not dared to chase. It is entertaining hitting that would not even be seen in most short form cricket games – pure theatre and exhilarating expression. From there, a catalyst is sparked. Jack Leach chases a ball to the boundary, diving head first, and injures himself in the process, yet Brendon McCullum tells him it's one of the best things he's ever seen and he should do it more often. People like Mark Wood thrive too – their super strengths celebrated and encouraged rather than over-analysed.

We follow this with a 3-0 series win in Pakistan, an unprecedented victory with our batsmen scoring at absurd rates. It seems to all fall out of the sky and work. When an airborne virus sweeps through the side and makes the entire team sick the day before the first Test, Stokes crawls to the door, opens it and shouts for Jack Leach next door, asking him to get a doctor. Everyone is very sick all night, before Stokesy texts the team in the morning saying, 'I'm up for it if you are.' Everyone agrees to play. We win the Test and become the first visiting team to win three matches in a series in Pakistan.

We start 2023 looking to continue this extraordinary run of results. It's the second Test in Wellington and we are batting last in a tight game. Where teams in the past would have batted to survive, this time we are trying to win. I am there, of course, trying to salvage something at the end. I hit Neil Wagner for four, meaning we only require two to win. He then bowls a bouncer that sails at least two metres over my head. I gesture at the umpires, but they don't call wide. I keep looking at them in disbelief, knowing what probably comes next. The next ball is at my body and I manage to get something on it, but I turn around to see the keeper take the catch. We have lost by a run. Unlike Sri Lanka though, I am not bent over, wanting the earth to swallow me up. We tried to win the game and we did everything we could to make a Test match entertaining. It's a consolation that surprisingly goes some way to healing the hurt I would have felt in the past. It's the kind of team I want to play in for another ten years, putting me